

FOR POTENTIAL SURROGATES

Surrogate Readiness Guide

Everything you need to know before you decide to become a surrogate.

Eligibility, process, reimbursements, choosing an agency, and real answers to the questions nobody else will ask.

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Egg donor 5 times. In this field since age four.

So you're thinking about surrogacy.

First — thank you. The fact that you are even considering this says something meaningful about who you are.

I have been in the surrogacy field since I was four years old. My mother founded Canadian Surrogacy Options in 1992. I was an egg donor five times myself. I have worked with hundreds of surrogates over the years — women who changed the lives of families in ways that are impossible to fully describe.

This guide is written for you with complete honesty. Not a recruitment pitch. Not a glossy brochure. Real information about what surrogacy involves, what is required, what you will experience, and what questions you should be asking before you decide.

“Surrogacy is one of the most generous things a person can do. It is also one of the most significant. This guide will help you decide whether it is right for you — with clear eyes.”

ROBYN PRICE · EXECUTIVE DIRECTOR, CANADIAN SURROGACY OPTIONS

What is surrogacy in Canada?

In Canada, surrogacy is legal and governed by the Assisted Human Reproduction Act. Here is what that means for you as a surrogate.

You are a gestational carrier.

In almost all Canadian surrogacy arrangements, you carry a baby that was created from the intended parents' embryo — or from donor material. You have no genetic connection to the baby. The embryo is transferred to your uterus at a fertility clinic after you complete medical screening.

You are not paid — you are reimbursed.

This is the part most people are surprised by. Canadian law prohibits paying a surrogate a fee or wage. What you receive are reimbursements for documented, pregnancy-related expenses — things like travel to appointments, lost wages for mandatory medical visits, maternity clothing, and medications.

IMPORTANT — LEGAL NOTICE

If anyone — an agency, a family, or anyone else — suggests paying you a fee beyond documented expense reimbursements, that is illegal in Canada. A reputable agency will never suggest this.

You choose your family.

You are never required to accept a match with a family you are not comfortable with. Matching is a mutual process. You review the intended parents' profile, they review yours, and both parties agree before the match is confirmed. You have the right to say no.

Do you qualify to be a surrogate?

Here are the eligibility requirements that most Canadian clinics and agencies use. These are not arbitrary — each one exists for medical, legal, or ethical reasons.

Medical Eligibility

- ☐ **You have had at least one previous successful pregnancy and birth** — This is non-negotiable at virtually every Canadian clinic. You must have carried and delivered before.
- ☐ **You are between 21 and 45 years of age**
- ☐ **You have a healthy BMI (generally 18.5 to 33)** — Some clinics have slightly different ranges. Your screening will confirm this.
- ☐ **You do not smoke or use recreational drugs**
- ☐ **You do not have uncontrolled chronic health conditions** — Some conditions are manageable and do not disqualify you. Your screening doctor will assess.
- ☐ **Your previous pregnancies and births were uncomplicated** — Complications are reviewed case by case. One caesarean section is usually fine. Multiple C-sections may be reviewed more carefully.
- ☐ **You are not currently pregnant or breastfeeding**

Financial & Lifestyle Eligibility

- ☐ **You are a Canadian citizen or permanent resident**
- ☐ **You are not currently receiving social assistance or government benefits** — Note: Receiving surrogacy reimbursements while on benefits can create legal complications for you. This is an important conversation to have before you proceed.
- ☐ **You have stable housing**
- ☐ **You have a support system — a partner, family member, or close friend** — Surrogacy is a significant undertaking. Having people around you who support your decision matters.

- ☐ You are not doing this primarily out of financial need — This is not a disqualifier — but it is something agencies and clinics look at carefully during screening. Surrogacy should be a choice, not a necessity.

What the process actually looks like

Here is what you can expect from application through to post-birth — in plain language, without the glossy version.

01

Application

You complete an application with your agency or directly with a family. This covers your medical history, previous pregnancies, lifestyle, and motivation.

02

Initial Screening Call

A conversation with the agency or family to get to know each other. No commitment at this stage — just a conversation.

03

Psychological Evaluation

A session with a registered psychologist who specialises in reproductive matters. This is required by most clinics. It is not a test you pass or fail — it is an assessment of your readiness and understanding.

04

Medical Screening

Full medical screening at the intended parents' fertility clinic. Bloodwork, uterine assessment, infectious disease testing. Your partner will also need to be tested if applicable.

05

Matching

Once you are medically and psychologically cleared, you are presented to families whose profiles you have reviewed. You can say no to any match.

06

Legal Agreements

Once matched, you retain an independent lawyer (paid for by the intended parents) who reviews and advises you on the surrogacy agreement. Nothing medical happens until this is signed.

07

Embryo Transfer

You complete a medicated cycle to prepare your uterus. The embryo transfer itself takes about 15–30 minutes and is not painful. A blood test 10–12 days later confirms whether it worked.

08

Pregnancy

If the transfer is successful, you are pregnant. You continue with your own OB/GYN for the pregnancy. Your expenses are reimbursed throughout.

Birth

The intended parents are present for the birth if you agree. What happens in the delivery room — who is present, who holds the baby — is agreed in advance. You have a say in all of it.

Post-Birth

Final reimbursements are processed. The intended parents handle the legal parentage process. Your role is complete. Most surrogates describe the post-birth period as a mix of joy, relief, and deep satisfaction.

What you will be reimbursed for

Here is a clear breakdown of what is and is not reimbursable under Canadian law. Everything must be documented with receipts.

REIMBURSABLE	NOT REIMBURSABLE
Maternity clothing allowance	A base salary or monthly wage
Travel to all medical appointments	Payment for carrying the baby
Childcare during appointments	Bonuses for successful transfer or birth
Lost wages for mandatory appointments	Cash payments without receipts
Medications and supplements	Compensation for pain or discomfort
Life and disability insurance premiums	Any amount that could be called commercial
Psychological counselling during journey	Payments exceeding actual documented expenses
Independent legal fees	—
Housekeeping if medically required	—

WHAT DOES TOTAL REIMBURSEMENT TYPICALLY LOOK LIKE?

Every journey is different — but most Canadian surrogates receive somewhere between **\$20,000 and \$35,000 CAD** in total reimbursements over the course of the journey, covering all the categories above. This is not income. It is reimbursement for real costs you incur.

The emotional reality — what nobody tells you

The clinical information about surrogacy is easy to find. What is harder to find is an honest account of what it actually feels like. Here is mine, based on 30+ years in this field.

“The bond is real — and it is also different.”

You will feel connected to this pregnancy. You will care about this baby. And when you hand that baby to its parents, most surrogates describe the feeling not as loss but as completion. You knew all along whose baby this was. That does not make the feelings small — it makes them profound.

“Not everyone in your life will understand.”

Some people will ask questions that feel intrusive. Some will project feelings onto you that are not yours. Your partner, your children, your parents — their reactions will vary. Prepare for this. Talk to them before you apply.

“Failed transfers are hard.”

Not every transfer results in a pregnancy. If a transfer fails, you will likely feel it more than you expected — even knowing the baby was never genetically yours. This is normal. Give yourself permission to grieve it.

“The relationship with the intended parents matters.”

Some surrogates become close friends with their IPs. Others maintain warm but boundaried relationships. Both are valid. What matters is that the relationship is respectful, communicative, and built on mutual appreciation.

“Most surrogates say they would do it again.”

Across all the surrogates I have worked with, the most consistent thing I hear years later is gratitude. Not just from the families — from the surrogates themselves. It changes you, in the best way.

How to choose the right agency

Your agency is your advocate throughout this journey. Here are the questions you should ask — and what good answers sound like.

“How long have you been working with surrogates?”

Experience matters. An agency that has been through complications, difficult matches, and unexpected situations is better equipped to support you.

“Who is my primary point of contact and how do I reach them?”

You should have a named person, not a general inbox. And that person should be reachable when things are hard, not just during business hours.

“How are my reimbursements handled?”

All reimbursements should flow through a trust account managed by a lawyer — not directly from the intended parents to you. This protects everyone.

“What happens if I or the intended parents need to withdraw?”

A good agency has a clear, fair policy for this. Ask what it is and get it in writing.

“Can I speak with surrogates who have worked with you before?”

Any reputable agency should be able to connect you with past surrogates who are willing to share their experience.

“What support do you offer me during the pregnancy — not just the IPs?”

Your wellbeing matters. A good agency checks in on you, advocates for you, and makes sure you never feel like the least important person in the process.

Talking to the people in your life

This is often the hardest part of the decision — not the medical screening, not the legal agreement, but the conversation at your kitchen table.

Your partner

Your partner's support is not optional — it is a requirement. Most clinics and agencies require your partner to participate in psychological screening and sign the surrogacy agreement. Beyond the legal requirement, carrying a pregnancy affects your relationship, your household, and your family's life. They need to be genuinely on board.

Your children

Children are more adaptable than we sometimes give them credit for. Age-appropriate honesty works best. Most children, when told simply that “mummy is growing a baby for another family who can't grow one themselves,” understand and accept this beautifully. What creates confusion is secrecy.

Your parents and extended family

Their reactions will vary. Some will be proud. Some will worry. Some will not understand at all. You do not need everyone's approval — but having honest conversations early, before you are pregnant, is far easier than managing reactions mid-journey.

A REMINDER

You are allowed to set limits on the questions you answer. “This is my decision and I have thought about it carefully” is a complete sentence.

Questions to ask yourself before you apply

Sit with these. There are no wrong answers — just honest ones.

- ☐ Why do I want to do this? Is my motivation something I feel good about?

- ☐ Does my partner fully support this decision?

- ☐ Have I talked to my children about what surrogacy means?

- ☐ Am I in a stable place financially, emotionally, and physically?

- ☐ Do I understand that I will not be paid — only reimbursed for real expenses?

- ☐ Am I comfortable carrying a baby I have no genetic connection to?

- ☐ Can I handle a failed transfer — and would I be willing to try again?

- ☐ Do I have people around me who will support me through this?

- ☐ Have I thought about what post-birth will feel like?

- ☐ Am I ready to share this pregnancy experience with another family?

- ☐ Do I understand that this will take 12 to 24 months of my life?

- ☐ Do I feel ready — not pressured, not financially desperate, but genuinely ready?

YOU'RE READY.

What comes *next.*

If you have read this guide, answered those questions honestly, and still feel the pull — then you might be ready. The next step is a conversation. Not a commitment. Just a chance to ask your questions, share your story, and get a feel for whether CSO is the right fit for your journey.

Book a free call with Robyn — calendly.com/cso-robyn

Canadian Surrogacy Options

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canadiansurrogacyoptions.com · robyn@canadiansurrogacyoptions.com

Little Miracles Egg Donation Services · little-miracles.ca

This guide is provided for informational purposes only and does not constitute legal or medical advice.
Eligibility requirements vary by clinic. Always consult with your agency and medical team.